

Wrapping the Reichstag

Hastily bundled up in a sheet, like a sofa left by the curb for the moving van — that's what the Reichstag looks like in Christo's drawing.

Christo Javacheff is the Bulgarian artist who wraps things. The Reichstag is the former capitol of Germany, burned by the Nazis in the coup that brought them to power, now a vacant presence in West Berlin near the Wall.

Wrapping the Reichstag will be Christo's greatest challenge. He hopes to pull it off next year if his elaborate negotiations

ARCHITECTURE By ROBERT CAMPBELL

with all the parties involved are successful. The Reichstag is in the British zone of West Berlin, near a Soviet war memorial, and its history and location combine to make it as politically sensitive as any building in the world. That is what Christo likes about it.

Christo was in town a few days ago to

open an exhibit of his work, including the Reichstag proposal, at the Institute of Contemporary Art. Anyone tempted to regard him as a nut would be fairly sure to be converted by the obvious charm, intelligence, sanity and verve with which he discusses his work.

Christo's work has always been interesting to architects and he is scheduled to receive an award from the American Institute of Architects at its convention next month in Kansas City (where Christo once wrapped sidewalks). He is best known in the US for the dramatic and beautiful Running Fence, the 24-mile row of taut white sails in California that crossed Sonoma and Marin counties to the sea for a few fleeting weeks in the fall of 1976.

Artists are supposed to be a step or two ahead of the rest of us, which makes them hard to understand. In Christo's case, the most important thing about his work isn't even visible in the final product. It's the fact that Christo is the first artist ever to see the creation of political consensus as a work of art.

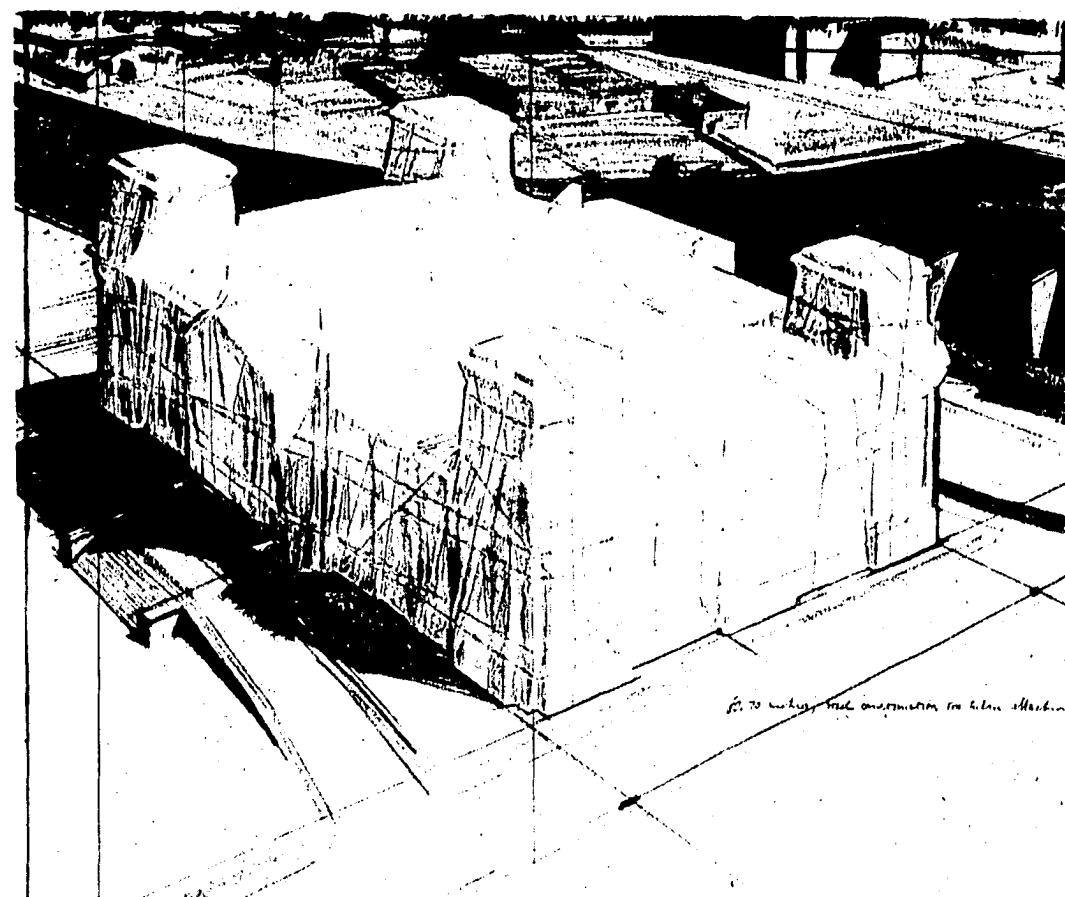
Christo picks projects that can't be achieved except by bringing diverse people together. He's a master developer, and the nearest analogies to his work in Boston are such efforts as the proposals for the Waterfront Hotel or Copley Place or Park Plaza — proposals that galvanize people, get them arguing, and produce results only if political consensus can be achieved.

That's why Christo likes the Reichstag. For the Running Fence, all Christo had to do was raise \$2 million in front money, spend four years negotiating land-use agreements with 59 ranchers, argue at 17 public hearings, and file a 450-page environmental impact statement. The Reichstag is more of a challenge.

"The Reichstag involves so much more unusual decision-making," Christo says delightedly. "There are so many countries. In Germany the socialists mostly defend my proposal, but the conservatives are afraid the Russians will make an international incident and close all the checkpoints.

"It will catalyze a lot of thinking, a lot of talking, a lot of judgments over value. It will involved so many kinds of judgment. This is what gives it value."

Christo's works are mystifying, sudden occurrences like blizzards, like the Lone Ranger passing through town, that



Wrapped Reichstag is shown in drawing by the artist Christo, who hopes to make it a reality next year.

come and go bringing people together for a time and leaving them, afterwards, buzzing with talk and memories. The Running Fence did all of that.

Christo feels strongly about his work being impermanent. The wrappings he

uses are tent-like, nomadic. Their fabric looks fragile, as if it could tear, and the ropes seem hastily slapped together. The wrappings transform solid buildings into rippling ghosts.

"They create alert looking," Christo

says, "because they look as if they are changing in the wind and they look as if they are going away."

Alert looking and political consensus — anyone who can stimulate those deserves more than a medal from the AIA.



Wrapped Allied Chemical Building in Times Square, shown in photocollage, was earlier Christo proposal.